MAX & MIA PODCAST - Daily English Conversations - EP 118

Max: Hey everyone and welcome back to another episode of Max & Mia Podcast. Glad you're here.

Mia: Hello everyone, we hope you are doing very well, and thank you for being here with us once again!

Max: Ok,So today's episode has a lot going on, but before we get to the main topic, we want to do something we've done before and honestly, people seem to like it.

Mia: It's a writing activity. And before you scroll past, hear us out.

Max: Writing in English is one of those skills that kind of gets ignored, right? Like, everyone focuses on speaking or listening, and writing just... sits there.

Mia: Forgotten in the corner.

Max: Exactly. So today's question is a bit of a controversial one, on purpose, because we want you to actually think, not just write two sentences and call it a day. The question is...

Mia: Imagine robots and AI taking over most jobs. Do we hit the brakes to save our jobs, or do we just learn to live in this new world?

Max: Think about it for a second.

Mia: You can answer now, you can answer at the end, totally up to you. But here's the challenge: try to push your vocabulary a little. Don't go for the first word that comes to mind. Look for something more precise, more specific. That's how you actually grow.

Max: Leave your answer in the comments. We'll read some of them, and at the end of the episode, we'll both give our own take on it.

Mia: Which I'm already nervous about, by the way.

Max: You should be. Okay, let's get into it.

[MAIN TOPIC]

Max: Okay, so, today we're covering a few different things, but let's kick it off with something grammar-related. And I know, I know, grammar sounds boring. But stick with us, because this one is actually useful.

Mia: It's about neither. And before you think "oh, I already know this one", you might. But probably only half of it.

Max: Right. So the version everyone knows is the one you'd use in a conversation like... say someone tells you "I don't like waking up early" and you feel the exact same way, you'd say "Neither do I." That's the classic move.

Mia: Super common. You've probably heard it a hundred times. But here's the thing, neither can do a lot more than just agree with negative statements.

Max: And the two uses that tend to fly under the radar are neither as an adjective and neither as a pronoun. Which, honestly, sound way more complicated than they are.

Mia: Let's start with the adjective one, because it's probably the simpler of the two. When you use neither as an adjective, you're placing it directly before a singular noun, and what you're doing is saying "not one, not the other." Both options are off the table.

Max: So for example, imagine there's an election and you're not exactly thrilled about your choices. You could say "Neither candidate is good." You're not picking sides. You're rejecting both. Same structure, different situations: "Neither side of the argument makes sense" or "Neither shoe fits me." Always singular, always right before the noun.

Mia: And that's the key thing to remember, singular. It trips a lot of people up because logically you're talking about two things, but the noun that follows neither is always singular.

Max: Now, the pronoun use is a little different. Here, neither stands on its own, it replaces the noun instead of sitting next to it. And this usually happens when the context is already clear, or when you pair it with "of."

Mia: The formula there is neither of, followed by something like "the," "my," "these," and then a plural noun. So "Neither of my parents speaks English." "I tried two keys, but neither worked." Or the really short version, someone asks "which one do you want?" and you just say "Neither."

Max: That last one is honestly the most satisfying way to use it.

Mia: It really is. Okay, so now that we've broken that down, let's actually hear it in action. Because reading rules is one thing, but hearing how it naturally fits into a real conversation is a whole different experience.

Max: So we've put together a short audio for you. This is conversation number one for today, and the goal is simple, listen for how neither shows up, notice the context, and see if you can catch which use it is each time.

Mia: Here we go.

[AUDIO #1 — Conversation: Dominic & Stacy]

Dominic: Okay so I finally went to check out those two apartments yesterday. The ones I've been going back and forth about for like, three weeks now.

Stacy: Oh finally! And? Which one are you going with?

Dominic: That's the thing... Neither of them felt right, honestly.

Stacy: Wait, seriously? After all that?

Dominic: I know, I know. But hear me out. The first one great location, right? Close to work, near that coffee place we like. But the moment I walked in, it just felt... I don't know, off. Like the layout made no sense. The bedroom was huge but the kitchen was basically a hallway.

Stacy: Ugh, I hate when that happens. Like, who designs these places?

Dominic: Right? And then the second one okay, the space was actually decent. Like, I could see myself living there. But the building itself was a mess. The elevator was broken, there was this weird smell in the hallway...

Stacy: Okay, yeah, no. Hard pass.

Dominic: Exactly. So yeah neither option really works for me right now. I'm kind of back to square one.

Stacy: I mean... that's frustrating, but also, I get it. You don't want to rush into something you're going to regret for the next year.

Dominic: Yeah, that's kind of where I landed. My roommate thinks I'm being too picky, but like — neither side of that argument is wrong, you know? He's not wrong that I need to decide soon, but I'm also not wrong for not wanting to settle.

Stacy: Honestly, your roommate means well, but he's been in the same place for what, four years? He doesn't really get the pressure of actively searching.

Dominic: Five years. And yeah, he doesn't. But whatever, we're not fighting about it or anything. It's fine. Hey, how did your job interview go, by the way? You had two this week, right?

Stacy: Ugh, don't remind me. Yeah, two interviews, and I don't know, neither of them went the way I hoped.

Dominic: What happened?

Stacy: The first one was fine, I guess. The people seemed nice, the role made sense. But then they mentioned the salary and I was like... yeah, that's not going to work.

Dominic: Ouch.

Stacy: And the second one okay, the pay was actually decent, but the vibe was so weird. Like, the interviewer kept cutting me off, and at one point she literally answered her phone in the middle of my response.

Dominic: No way.

Stacy: I'm dead serious. And I just sat there thinking neither candidate in this conversation is making a great impression, and one of them isn't even me.

Dominic: That's actually a great way to put it.

Stacy: I thought so. But yeah, I walked out of both feeling pretty drained. It's exhausting, honestly.

Dominic: It really is. And the worst part is you can't really tell anyone how bad it went because then everyone starts giving you advice you didn't ask for.

Stacy: Oh god, yes. My mom already texted me like four articles about "how to ace your next interview."

Dominic: Classic.

Stacy: I love her, but neither the timing nor the articles were helpful.

Dominic: Okay but that one was pretty good grammar-wise, not gonna lie.

Stacy: I've been listening to too many podcasts, what can I say.

Dominic: Haven't we all.

[MAX & MIA — Post-Audio Commentary]

Max: Okay so listeners, What did you think?

Mia: I liked it. And what I found interesting is that neither of them was actually talking about grammar, they were just venting, you know? But the word kept coming up because that's genuinely how people talk when they're weighing two options and rejecting both.

Max: That's the thing. When something is actually part of your vocabulary, you don't think about it, it just comes out. And I think that last line from Stacy is worth going back to. "Neither the timing nor the articles were helpful." That one's a slightly more advanced structure, and it landed perfectly because the conversation had already built up to it.

Mia: Right it didn't feel like she was showing off. It just fit. Alright, before we move on, there's actually something we didn't touch on earlier and we should, because it's a question that comes up a lot.

Max: Neither versus none.

Mia: Exactly. And honestly, mixing these two up is really common even at higher levels. So, neither, as we covered, is strictly for two things. Two apartments, two interviews, two candidates. That's its lane.

Max: None, on the other hand, is for three or more. So if you visited five apartments and walked out of all of them disappointed, you wouldn't say "neither worked." You'd say "none of them worked." The moment you go beyond two, neither is off the table.

Mia: Simple rule, easy to forget in the moment. But now you know two things, neither. Three or more, none. Keep that in your back pocket.

[NEW TOPIC: "So do I" vs. "Neither do I"]

Max: Okay new topic. And this one connects directly to what we've been talking about, so the timing works out pretty well.

Mia: We're looking at short agreements. Specifically, "So do I" and "Neither do I" and why getting them right is actually trickier than it sounds.

Max: So the basic idea is this: when someone says something and you feel the same way, you want to agree without just repeating everything they said. That's where these structures come in. But here's where people stumble, the auxiliary verb you use has to match the tense of what the other person said. You can't just pick one and stick with it forever.

Mia: Let's walk through it. If someone says "I love pizza" present simple you mirror that with "So do I." The auxiliary is do because that's what present simple uses. Now if they said "I went to Paris" past simple you'd say "So did I." Not "So do I." The tense shifts, so the auxiliary shifts with it.

Max: And it's not just regular tenses. If someone says "I can swim" you're dealing with a modal verb now so you carry that modal over: "So can I." Same logic applies to should, would, will, have whatever is in their sentence is what you're working with.

Mia: Now flip it to the negative side. If someone says "I'm not tired" that's a negative statement with to be your agreement would be "Neither am I." Not "Neither do I." The verb to be doesn't use do, so neither should your response.

Max: And that's really the core of it you're not memorizing fixed phrases, you're learning to listen closely to what someone says and reflect the right auxiliary back. Once that clicks, it becomes instinct.

Mia: It's one of those things that sounds small but makes a huge difference in how natural you sound. Alright let's put it to the test. Conversation number two is coming up. Listen for how these agreements show up and pay attention to which auxiliaries they reach for.

Max: Here we go.

[AUDIO #2 — Conversation: Lila & Zach]

Lila: Okay, I have to ask did you end up watching that documentary last night? The one about deep sea creatures?

Zach: I did, yeah. I couldn't sleep after, honestly. Some of those things should not exist.

Lila: Neither should the person who decided to film them up close, but here we are.

Zach: Exactly. But no, it was genuinely fascinating. Like, I had no idea how little we actually know about the ocean.

Lila: Neither did I. I went in expecting, like, pretty fish and weird jellyfish, and instead I got existential dread at eleven pm.

Zach: That's the experience, yeah. Hey, are you still going to that workshop thing on Saturday? The photography one?

Lila: I'm planning to, yeah. I've been trying to actually commit to things lately instead of just signing up and then bailing last minute.

Zach: So have I, actually. I registered for that writing class two weeks ago and I've shown up every single session, which is honestly a record for me.

Lila: Wait, really? How is it?

Zach: It's good. Harder than I expected. The instructor is kind of brutal with feedback, but in a way that's actually useful, you know? Like, she doesn't just say "this doesn't work" she tells you exactly why.

Lila: That's rare. I'd take brutal and useful over vague and polite any day.

Zach: So would I. Actually, can I ask you something? Have you ever felt like you're improving at something but you can't really point to where or how?

Lila: Oh, constantly. It's like one day things just click a little more than before but you didn't see it happening.

Zach: Yes. That's exactly it. I feel like my writing is getting somewhere but I couldn't explain what changed.

Lila: I felt that way with photography for a long time. You just have to trust the process, which is annoying advice but it's true.

Zach: It really is. Okay, totally different topic. Did you hear about the new place that opened up near the library? I think it's a brunch spot or something.

Lila: I did! Someone sent me a picture of the menu. It looked incredible.

Zach: So did the photos I saw. I've been meaning to go but I haven't had a free weekend in forever.

Lila: Neither have I. Between the workshop, my cousin's visit, and trying to actually sleep eight hours like a functioning adult my weekends have just disappeared.

Zach: The sleep thing is real. I've been going to bed earlier and it's changed my life, I'm not even joking.

Lila: So have I, actually well, trying to. I'm not always successful.

Zach: Neither am I. Last night was a disaster. I told myself eleven o'clock and then somehow it was one thirty and I was watching a deep sea documentary.

Lila: We've come full circle.

Zach: We really have. But okay, let's actually plan the brunch thing. Like, genuinely put it on the calendar.

Lila: I'm in. Pick a date and I will show up. No bailing.

Zach: Same. I feel like we say this every time though.

Lila: So do I. But this time I mean it.

Zach: So do I.

[MAX & MIA — Post-Audio Commentary]

Mia: Okay, that ending. I love when a conversation just closes like that.

Max: It's simple but it works. And what I think is worth pointing out is how naturally the tense shifts happened throughout. Like, Zach says "I've been meaning to go" and Lila doesn't say "So do I" she goes a different route entirely because the moment didn't call for it. Real conversations don't just hand you perfect setups back to back.

Mia: Exactly. And that's actually the harder skill — knowing when to use these structures and when to just... respond like a human. It's not about forcing them in, it's about having them ready when the moment is right.

Max: Which is really what all of this comes down to.

Mia: Alright, before we move on, we want to hear from you. Take any exchange from that conversation, any one, and try rewriting it. Change the tense, change the context, make it your own.

Max: We're not looking for perfect. We're looking for the attempt. That's where the actual learning happens.

[NEW TOPIC: "Wish" and "If only"]

Mia: Okay, last topic of the day and this one hits a little differently because it's not just grammar, it's emotion.

Max: We're talking about wish and if only. And these two are essentially expressing the same thing a desire for something to be different. The difference is mostly intensity. If only tends to carry more weight, more feeling. But the grammar behind both works the same way.

Mia: Here's the part that catches people off guard even though you're talking about the present, you use a past tense verb. So if right now, today, you don't have enough time and you wish you did you'd say "I wish I had more time." Not "I wish I have." The situation is present, but the structure reaches back into the past tense to signal that it's not real. It's something you want but don't have.

Max: And if only works exactly the same way. "If only I had more time." Same meaning, just a bit more dramatic. Which, depending on the situation, is completely valid.

Mia: Now when you're talking about the past, about something that already happened and can't be changed, that's where regret lives. And for that, you go one step further past perfect. So instead of just past simple, you're using had plus the past participle. "I wish I hadn't said that." "If only I had listened." The thing already happened, and you're looking back at it wishing it had gone differently.

Max: So to keep it clean present situation you want to change: past simple. Past situation you regret: past perfect. The further back the feeling goes, the further back the grammar goes with it.

Mia: And honestly, once you start noticing this structure, you'll hear it everywhere. People use it all the time without realizing it's even a grammar point.

Max: Alright let's close out today with one last audio. Same idea as before — two friends, real conversation. Listen for how wish and if only come up, and pay attention to whether the situation they're describing is present or past. That'll tell you exactly why the verb is doing what it's doing.

Mia: Here we go. Last one.

[AUDIO #3 — Conversation: Sloane & Beckett]

Sloane: Can I just say I wish this week was over already and it's only Wednesday.

Beckett: What happened?

Sloane: Everything just kind of piled up at once. The project at work got pushed forward, my landlord is being impossible about the heating, and I just — I don't know. I wish I had taken that extra day off last weekend when I had the chance.

Beckett: Why didn't you?

Sloane: Because I thought I'd use the time to get ahead on things. Which, spoiler, did not happen.

Beckett: If only good intentions actually translated into productivity.

Sloane: Right? That would be great. How are you doing, though? You look surprisingly calm for someone who had that presentation yesterday.

Beckett: I mean... it went okay. Not great. I kind of rushed through the last section because I ran out of time.

Sloane: Oh no.

Beckett: Yeah. I wish I had practiced the timing more. I did the whole thing maybe twice at home and apparently that was not enough.

Sloane: Did anyone notice?

Beckett: My manager definitely noticed. She didn't say anything during, but after she was like "the second half felt a little compressed." Which is a very polite way of saying I blew it.

Sloane: I mean, it's one presentation. It's not the end of the world.

Beckett: No, I know. I just if only I had started preparing earlier. I had the whole week and I kept telling myself I had more time than I actually did.

Sloane: I do that constantly. It's like I genuinely believe future me is going to be more motivated than current me.

Beckett: And she never is.

Sloane: Never. Not once has she come through. Okay but genuinely, are you okay? Like, beyond the presentation.

Beckett: Yeah, I'm fine. Just a little stuck in my head about it. I keep replaying the moment I realized I was running out of time and the mild panic that followed.

Sloane: I wish I could tell you that gets easier but I still do that exact same thing after anything that doesn't go perfectly.

Beckett: That's not comforting at all, Sloane.

Sloane: I know, I'm sorry. What I mean is you're not alone in it. Everyone does the replay thing.

Beckett: Fair enough. Can we go get coffee? I feel like I need to be somewhere that isn't this building for twenty minutes.

Sloane: Yes. Absolutely yes. I wish I had suggested that an hour ago.

Beckett: If only you had.

Sloane: Was that sarcasm?

Beckett: Sixty percent sarcasm, forty percent genuine.

Sloane: I'll take it. Let's go.

[MAX & MIA — Post-Audio Commentary]

Max: Sloane and Beckett. I liked that one.

Mia: Same. And what stood out to me was how the regret and the present frustration were layered throughout like, Beckett is dealing with something that already happened, the presentation, and Sloane is reacting to her week in real time. So you naturally get both uses without either of them feeling like it was put there on purpose.

Max: And that last exchange "I wish I had suggested that an hour ago." "If only you had." — that's the kind of thing you'd actually say. It's almost throwaway, but grammatically it's doing exactly what we talked about. Past perfect, looking back, slight regret, slight humor. Perfect.

Mia: Alright that wraps up the content for today. Which means it's time for the outro. And we did promise something at the top of the episode.

Max: We did. The question.

Mia: We asked you to sit with it, write about it, push your vocabulary. Now it's our turn.

Max: I'll go first. And I want to be straightforward about where I stand, I don't think slowing down technological progress is a realistic option, and honestly, I'm not sure it would even be desirable if it were. Throughout history, every major shift in how we work has displaced certain jobs and created new ones. The printing press, the industrial revolution, the internet

none of those were paused because people were scared of what they'd replace. What made the difference each time wasn't resistance, it was the capacity to adapt education systems that evolved, institutions that responded, people who retrained and repositioned themselves. The real issue has never been the technology. It's whether society moves fast enough to support people through the transition. And I think the energy is better spent building those safety nets and rethinking how we prepare people for a shifting job market, rather than trying to hold back something that, at this point, no one country or institution could stop even if they wanted to.

Mia: Okay and I hear that, I really do. But I think that framing lets a lot of people off the hook. My position is that progress being inevitable doesn't mean it's happening responsibly. There's a difference between not being able to stop something and choosing not to slow it down long enough to think. What worries me isn't the technology itself it's the pace. When automation moves faster than education systems can respond, faster than policy can catch up, faster than communities can absorb the people who pay the price aren't the ones making the decisions. And I think we have a collective responsibility to ask who benefits and who gets left behind, before we celebrate every new wave of disruption. That's not anti-progress. That's just being honest about the fact that "adapt or get left behind" is a much easier thing to say when you're not the one being left behind.

Max: And that's exactly why this question is worth writing about. Because there's no clean answer there's just where you stand and why.

Mia: Drop your take in the comments. Seriously, we read them. And if you tried the writing challenge today whether it was two sentences or two paragraphs that already counts.

Max: That's it for today. Thanks for spending this time with us take care of yourselves, and we'll see you in the next one.

Mia: See you then.